

What is the environmental impact of AI data centers really?

Posted by u/FerdinandvonAegir124 • • 0 points • 3 comments

All the time I'm seeing conflicting answers regarding AI's environmental impact, regarding things such as pollution, power and water use.

What is the impact really?

Comments

u/timf3d • 2 points • 2026-01-02 03:24 UTC

I think the problem isn't so much the environmental impact but the fact that there's no upside for it. We've been told that it's going to destroy all the jobs, enrich those who are already billionaires, and the upside is that it's going to rape the planet of all natural resources and accelerate the destruction of all life as we know it. So in light of all those wonderful benefits, the minor cost of draining Lake Superior seems trivial.

u/archpaw • 0 points • 2026-01-02 00:00 UTC

[Here's an in-depth blog post.](<https://andymasley.substack.com/p/a-cheat-sheet-for-conversations-about>) Which is a cheat sheet for [this more in-depth one.] (<https://andymasley.substack.com/p/individual-ai-use-is-not-bad-for>) Water use is trivial compared to food. Electricity seems to be pretty small compared to a lot of things people don't worry about. But one problem is that since AI data centers have a lot of power use in one spot, it can put strain on the grid and even raise prices in that spot. But it saves money and electricity compared to having it be more distributed.

u/FerdinandvonAegir124 • -1 points • 2026-01-02 00:04 UTC

So it really is almost negligible